

SEA SPRAY: VERSES  
AND TRANSLATIONS  
BY T. W. ROLLESTON

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VERSES AND TRANSLATIONS \*\*\***

# SEA SPRAY: VERSES AND TRANSLATIONS BY T. W. ROLLESTON

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1909

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TO  
THE LADY OF THE RING

Thanks are due to Messrs. Harrap & Co., London, for permission to include in this volume three poems which are introduced into the writer's forthcoming prose book, "The High Deeds of Finn and other Bardic Romances of Ancient Ireland." The poems in question are *Cois na Teineadh*, *Midir the Proud*, and the *Song of Finn*. Some others have appeared in the *Spectator*, the *Irish Homestead*, and the *Westminster Gazette*, to the editors of which acknowledgments are due.

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## SEA SPRAY

What shall we do with our day? you ask—  
A June day fair to the heart's desire—  
Lie in the meadow, and lounge and bask  
Over books and tobacco? Or do you aspire  
To conquer the summit that yesterday  
We marked for our own ere your visit end?  
Or shall we go riding, or fishing? Nay,  
For the scent of the sea's on the air, my friend.  
We shall go to the head of the reedy lake,  
And there, in a brake by a fir-grove, find  
Two long canoes with arching deck,  
Sea-riders, strong for a day of wind;  
And oh, what a song shall the bright wind sing us  
When clear of the shallows and clear of the sedge,  
While the narrowing stream and the ebb-tide swing us  
'Twixt sea and mountain to Wicklow Bridge!

But here beware! for the ebb goes roaring  
Through half the arches, and half are dry,  
And stakes and stones are ready for goring  
Your Rob-Roy's timbers as down you fly.  
And beyond the Bridge, in the deep sea-current,  
Where the rope-maze crosses from quay to quay,  
You'll need your head and your arm I warrant,  
To fight the eddies and find your way.  
There lifts your prow with the long pulsation  
That tells how near us the glad seas are!  
There lifts the heart with the old elation,

To meet the surf at the harbour-bar!

The North wind marshals the ranks of ocean,  
And on they sweep with a strength serene,  
Till the tide-race ruffles the mighty motion  
And curls the crests of the rollers green.  
The breakers flash on the sand-bank yonder,  
And the cavern'd curve of the rock-walled bay  
Is loud with clamour of hoarse sea-thunder  
As the wave recoils in a blast of spray.

And I know a cleft among grim rock-masses,  
Where if wind blow strong and the light come fair,  
When the sea-cave roars and the spray-jet flashes,  
A rainbow floats in the sunny air.

At the Head's wild verge, where the tideways quicken,  
And eddies hollow the smooth sea-caves,  
Our Rob-Roys plunge as the breakers thicken,  
And bury their decks in the rearing waves.  
We round the Point in the surge and welter  
Of clashing billows and blinding foam—  
Then mile on mile, in the cliff-wall's shelter,  
In calm new seas to the South we roam.

O bays of Wicklow, and gorse-crown'd headlands  
Whose scent blows far on the seaward breeze,  
How oft have I yearned in the tranquil midlands  
For one brave shock of your lifting seas!  
How oft it may be in days hereafter  
Shall rise the thought of you, phantom-fair,  
Shall steal the sound of the sea-waves' laughter  
On ears grown dull with time and care!  
Waves, wash my spirit, and lonely places,  
If well I loved you, and aught you knew,  
Mark deep my heart with immortal traces  
Of shining days when I dwelt with you!

## MARCH WINDS

Wind, O wind of the Spring, thine old enchantment renewing,  
How at the shock of thy might wakens within me a cry!  
Out of what wonderful lands, never trodden by man, never told of,  
Lands where never a ship anchored or trafficker fared,  
Comest thou, breathing like flame till the brown earth flames into blossom,  
Quick'ning the sap of old woods swayed in thy stormy embrace,  
Rousing in depths of the heart wild waves of an infinite longing,  
Longing for freedom and life, yearning for Springs that are dead!  
Surely the far blue sea, foam-fleck'd with the speed of thy coming  
Brighten'd in laughter abroad, sang at the feet of the isles,  
Sang in a tumult of joy as my soul sings trembling with passion,  
Trembling with passion and hope, wild with the spirit of Spring.  
Ah, what dreams re-arise, half pain half bliss to remember,  
Hearing the storm of thy song blown from the height of the skies:—  
*Something remains upon earth to be done, to be dared, to be sought for,*  
*Up with the anchor once more—out with the sails to the blast!*  
*Out to the shock of the seas that encircle the Fortunate Islands,*  
*Vision that burns in the blood, home of the Wind of the Spring.*

## MIDIR THE PROUD INVITES QUEEN ETAIN TO FAIRYLAND<sup>[1]</sup>

Come with me, Etain, O come away,  
To that Oversea Land of mine!  
Where music haunts the happy day,  
And rivers run with wine.  
Careless we live, and young and gay,  
And none saith 'mine' or 'thine.'

Golden curls on the proud young head,  
And pearls in the tender mouth—  
Manhood, womanhood, white and red,  
And love that grows not loth  
When all the world's desires are dead,  
And all the dreams of youth.

Away from the cloud of Adam's sin!  
Away from grief and care!  
This flowery land thou dwellest in  
Seems rude to us and bare,  
For the naked strand of the Happy Land  
Is twenty times as fair.

Come, Etain, come to thine ancient home,  
And let these mortals be,  
Whose world is a glimmer of rainbow foam  
On the breast of a boundless Sea!  
We shall watch it go, as we watch'd it come,  
From the Kingdom of Faëry.

[1] This poem is based on an Irish original in “The Courtship of Etain.” See Leahy’s *Heroic Romances of Ireland*, vol. i., p. 26.

## THE SPELL-STRUCK

She walks as she were moving  
    Some mystic dance to tread,  
So falls her gliding footstep,  
    So leans her list'ning head;  
For once to fairy harping  
    She danced upon the hill,  
And through her brain and bosom  
    The music pulses still.

Her eyes are bright and tearless,  
    But wide with yearning pain:  
She longs for nothing earthly,  
    But oh, to hear again  
The sound that held her breathless  
    Upon her moonlit path—  
The golden fairy music  
    That filled the lonely rath!

Her lips have felt strange kisses  
    And drunk the wine of death,  
Nor earthly love nor laughter  
    Shall stir their tender breath.  
She's dead to all things living  
    Since that November Eve,  
And when They call her earthward,  
    No living thing will grieve.

## COIS NA TEINEADH

Where glows the Irish hearth with peat  
There lives a subtle spell—  
The faint blue smoke, the gentle heat  
The moorland odours tell

Of white roads winding by the edge  
Of bare untamed land,  
Where dry stone wall or ragged hedge  
Runs wide on either hand

To cottage lights that lure you in  
From rainy Western skies;  
And by the friendly glow within  
Of simple talk, and wise,

And tales of magic, love or arms  
From days when princes met  
To listen to the lay that charms  
The Connacht peasant yet.

There Honour shines through passions dire,  
There beauty blends with mirth—  
Wild hearts, ye never did aspire  
Wholly for things of earth!

Cold, cold this thousand years—yet still  
On many a time-stained page  
Your pride, your truth, your dauntless will,  
Burn on from age to age.

And still around the fires of peat  
Live on the ancient days;  
There still do living lips repeat  
The old and deathless lays.

And when the wavering wreaths ascend,  
Blue in the evening air,  
The soul of Ireland seems to bend  
Above her children there.

# WILLIAM MORRIS

† *Oct. 4, 1896*

Singer of Jason's quest and Sigurd's doom!  
Teller of vision-haunted wanderings!  
Who touched a strange new music from the strings  
Of old Romance—a space amidst the gloom  
Of cloudy centuries thou didst illumine;  
And there thy word a dreamlike splendour flings  
On crown and helm—and even the tears of things  
Brighten thy morning world's immortal bloom.

Yet some, great Craftsman, reverence thee more  
That Beauty, coldly throned among the stars,  
Came at thy lure to tread the homely earth:  
And, sweet and kindly as in days of yore,  
Played with our children, graced our household cares,  
And knelt content by many a quiet hearth.

# TO JOHN O'LEARY

*Dedication of a Book of Irish Verses by various hands*[\[2\]](#)

Because you suffered for the Cause;  
Because you strove with voice and pen  
To serve a Law above all laws  
That purifies the hearts of men;

Because you failed, and grew not slack,  
Not sullen, not disconsolate,  
Nor stooped to seek a lower track,  
But showed your soul a match for Fate;

Because you hated all things base,  
And held your country's honour high;  
Because you wrought in Time and Space  
Not heedless of Eternity;

Because you loved the nobler part  
Of Erin,—so we bring you here  
Words such as once the Irish heart  
On Irish lips rejoiced to hear:

Strains that have little chance to live  
With those that Davis' clarion blew,  
But all the best we have to give  
To Mother Erin and to you.

[2] “Poems and Ballads of Young Ireland, 1888.”

# THE GRAVE OF RURY

Clear as air, the western waters  
                     evermore their sweet unchanging song  
Murmur in their stony channels  
                     round O’Conor’s sepulchre in Cong.

Crownless, hopeless, here he lingered;  
                   felt the years go by him like a dream,  
 Heard the far-off roar of conquest  
                   murmur faintly like the singing stream.

Here he died, and here they tomb'd him,  
                   men of Fechin, chanting round his grave.  
 Did they know, ah, did they know it,  
                   what they buried by the babbling wave?

Now above the sleep of Rury  
                   holy things and great have passed away;  
 Stone by stone the stately Abbey  
                   falls and fades in passionless decay.

Darkly grows the quiet ivy,  
pale the broken arches glimmer through;  
Dark upon the cloister-garden  
dreams the shadow of the ancient yew.

Through the roofless aisles the verdure  
                   flows, the meadow-sweet and foxglove bloom;  
 Earth, the mother and consoler,  
                   winds soft arms about the lonely tomb.

Peace and holy gloom possess him,  
                    last of Gaelic monarchs of the Gael,  
Slumbering by the young, eternal  
                    river-voices of the western vale.

Ruraidh O'Conchobhar, last High King of Ireland, spent the closing fifteen years of his life in the monastery of St. Fechin at Cong, Co. Mayo. His grave is still shown in that most beautiful and pathetic of Irish ruins. Some accounts have it that his remains were afterwards transferred to Clonmacnois by the Shannon.

## SONG OF MAELDUIN

There are veils that lift, there are bars that fall,  
There are lights that beckon and winds that call—  
    Goodbye!

There are hurrying feet, and we dare not wait;  
For the hour is on us, the hour of Fate,  
The circling hour of the flaming Gate—  
    Goodbye, goodbye, goodbye!

Fair, fair they shine through the burning zone,  
Those rainbow gleams of a world unknown—  
    Goodbye!

And oh, to follow, to seek, to dare,  
When step by step in the evening air  
Floats down to meet us the cloudy stair—  
    Goodbye, goodbye, goodbye!

The cloudy stair of the Brig o' Dread  
Is the dizzy path that our feet must tread—  
    Goodbye!

O all ye children of Nights and Days  
That gather and wonder and stand at gaze,  
And wheeling stars in your lonely ways—  
    Goodbye, goodbye, goodbye!

The music calls and the Gates uncloze,  
Onward and upward the wild way goes—  
    Goodbye!

We die in the bliss of a great new birth.  
O fading phantoms of pain and mirth,

O fading loves of the old green Earth,  
Goodbye, goodbye, goodbye!

## THE SHANNON AT FOYNES

Into the West, where o'er the wide Atlantic  
The lights of sunset gleam,  
From its high sources in the heart of Erinn  
Flows the great stream.

Yet back in stormy cloud or viewless vapour  
The wandering waters come,  
And faithfully across the trackless heaven  
Find their old home.

But ah, the tide of life that flows unceasing  
Into the luring West  
Returns no more, to swell with kindlier fulness  
The Mother's breast!

## SONNET

*On reading a Dublin newspaper in the train,  
April 16, 1904*

Night falls: the emerald pastures turn to grey,  
Young stars appear, a mystic beauty thrills  
The dusk above the line of far-off hills,  
Where late the splendours of the end of Day,  
Sad and majestic, flamed and passed away.  
In dust and thunder speeding to the Sea  
The train flies on, yet eve's serenity,  
Great and untroubled, holds the world in sway.

Then, turning from that realm of lofty life,  
Again my eyes upon the printed page  
Fall, and again I hear but cries of rage,  
Brawlers and bigots, every word a knife;  
While Thought, the fair land's fairest heritage,  
Lies drowned in clamour of ignoble strife.

## A RAILWAY JOURNEY

We've cleared the station—free at last  
From darkness, din, and worry;  
By red-brick villas, shady roads  
And garden-plots we hurry.  
And now green miles of pasture-land  
Flit by, with budding hedges,  
And far to Southward I can see  
The purple mountain ridges.

My fellow-travellers pretermite,  
Seeing there is no danger,  
That anxious glance with which we greet  
The presence of a stranger.  
Whom have we? First, some man of means  
(I guess), brow-wrinkled, dull-eyed,  
His face the index of a soul  
By cares unworthy sullied.

And then a lady, whom I deem  
Some mask of Fashion merely;  
And last, a maid of nineteen years,  
Who, since I've seen her clearly,  
Has won the careless glance I gave  
To linger, as delighted  
As with some green-rimmed waterspring  
In midst of deserts blighted.

What is her charm? Not very fair,  
Nor luring to the senses—

And yet her frank and girlish grace,  
Her lack of small pretences,  
Her clear, unconscious hazel eyes,  
Pure lips, and simple neatness,  
Fill my heart as I gaze on her  
With deep and tender sweetness.  
          . . . . .

The train has rolled without a break  
For half an hour or more, perhaps;  
My wealthy cit has fall'n asleep,  
Will soon begin to snore, perhaps;  
Kind Morpheus touch'd him as he scanned  
The last returns of traffic—  
The lady clad in furs and silks  
Is trifling with her *Graphic*.

The maiden looks with dreaming eyes  
As wood and field and river  
Flash past our roaring carriage-wheels  
In whirling dance forever.  
What are the thoughts that smooth her brows  
To such content, I wonder,  
While clangs about our silent group  
The railroad's rhythmic thunder?

But now more slow the landscape moves—  
We reach a little station—  
And how the maiden's face has changed,  
Lit up with expectation!  
A brother, with his sister's eyes,  
Brown-cheeked from sun and heather,  
Awaits her; and with half a sigh  
I watch them leave together.

The heavy train regathers speed,  
And minute after minute  
The country station drops behind—

Some spell is surely in it!  
For now my fellow-travellers seem  
No mark for peevish scorning—  
Those withered lives had surely once  
The innocence of morning.

But ah, the world's use, soon or late,  
Dispels the early glamour,  
And faint the spheral music rings  
In this incessant clamour!  
Save when, at times, in some strange lull  
Of tyrannous self-seeking,  
The heart of memory is thrilled  
By ancient voices speaking.

And then the cloud in which we walk  
Rolls by us, and from dreaming  
We wake to see the primal world  
In beauty round us gleaming;  
Then common things to common eyes  
Their secret life surrender,  
And glow beneath the light of day  
With visionary splendour.

. . . . .

What wrought me so? I only know  
I bowed in homage ardent  
Before some high mysterious Power  
A heart a little hardened.  
That glory flashed upon a soul  
By doubt and self o'erladen,  
When all I saw in very sooth  
Was but a simple maiden.

## CYCLING SONG

In the airy whirling wheel is the springing strength of steel,  
And the sinews grow to steel, day by day,  
Till you feel your pulses leap at the easy swing and sweep  
As the hedges flicker past upon the way.  
Then it's out to the kiss of the morning breeze,  
And the rose of the morning sky,  
And the long brown road, where the tired spirit's load  
Slips off as the leagues go by!

Black-and-silver, swift and strong, with a pleasant undersong  
From the steady rippling murmur of the chain—  
Half a thing of life and will, you may feel it start and thrill  
With a quick elastic answer to the strain,  
As you ride to the kiss of the morning breeze,  
And the rose of the morning sky,  
And the long brown road, where the tired spirit's load  
Slips off as the leagues go by!

Miles a hundred you may run from the rising of the sun  
To the gleam of the first white star;  
You may ride through twenty towns, meet the sun upon the downs  
And the wind on the mountain scaur.  
Then it's out to the kiss of the morning breeze  
And the rose of the morning sky,  
And the long brown road, where the tired spirit's load  
Slips off as the leagues go by!

Down the fragrant country-side, through the woodland's summer pride  
You have come in your forenoon spin;

And you never would have guessed how delicious is the rest  
In the shade by the wayside inn,  
When you've sought the kiss of the morning breeze  
And the rose of the morning sky,  
And the long brown road, where the tired spirit's load  
Slips off as the leagues go by!

Oh, there's many a one who teaches that the shining river-reaches  
Are the place to spend a long June day;  
But give me the whirling wheel and a boat of air and steel  
To float upon the King's highway!  
Oh, give me the kiss of the morning breeze  
And the rose of the morning sky,  
And the long brown road, where the tired spirit's load  
Slips off as the leagues go by!

## BALLADE OF THE “CHESHIRE CHEESE” IN FLEET STREET<sup>[3]</sup>

I know a home of antique ease  
Within the smoky city's pale,  
A spot wherein the spirit sees  
Old London through a thinner veil.  
The modern world, so stiff and stale,  
You leave behind you, when you please,  
For long clay pipes and great old ale  
And supper in the “Cheshire Cheese.”

Beneath this board, Burke's, Goldsmith's knees  
Were often thrust—so runs the tale—  
'Twas here the Doctor took his ease,  
And wielded speech that, like a flail,  
Thresh'd out the golden truth: All hail  
Great souls! that met on nights like these,  
For talk and laughter, pipes and ale,  
And supper in the “Cheshire Cheese.”

By kindly sense, and old decrees  
Of England's use you set your sail—  
We press to never-furrow'd seas,  
For vision-worlds we breast the gale;  
And still we seek, and still we fail,  
For still the “glorious phantom” flees<sup>4</sup>—  
Ah, well! no phantoms are the ale  
And suppers of the “Cheshire Cheese.”

*Envoi*

If doubts or debts thy soul assail,  
If Fashion's forms its current freeze,  
Try a long pipe, a glass of ale,  
And supper at the "Cheshire Cheese."

[3] Meeting-place of The Rhymers' Club, 1892, 3.

[4] ... "Graves from which a glorious phantom may  
Burst to illumine our tempestuous day."—SHELLEY.

## DORA

I know not whether I love you, Dora:  
Your beauty moves me, I know not how—  
Your eyes that shine with a joy unspoken,  
Your pride and sweetness of bosom and brow.  
But I had not deemed that our earth could fashion  
Of flesh and spirit so rare a thing—  
And you lift my heart with the nameless passion  
That stirs young blood in the dawn of spring.

I know not whether I love you, Dora,  
Nor if you be what a man may wed.  
Whence came that glory of ancient Hellas  
That seems to hover about your head?  
Have you roamed with Artemis, talked with Pallas?  
Did Hera lend you that look sublime?  
Did Bacchus give in a rose-wreathed chalice  
That conquering charm of the youth of Time?

I know not whether I love you, Dora,  
But well I know you are not for me,  
So darken'd and marr'd with the bitter travail  
Of things that are not, and fain would be.  
Keep, keep for ever your grace and gladness,  
Bend once to bless me your brow of snow—  
Then meet me next like some far-off sadness,  
Some dead ambition of long ago.

## A RING'S SECRET

Can you forgive me, that I wear,  
Dearest, a curl of sunny hair,  
Not yours—yet for the sake of Love,  
And tender faith it minds me of?  
'Tis in this quaint old signet ring,  
A curious, chased, engraven thing  
That in some window charm'd my eye  
And told of the last century.  
Pure gold it was, but dull and blotch'd,  
And bright'ning it one day, I touch'd  
A spring that oped a little lid;  
And there, for generations hid  
In its small shrine of pallid gold—  
They made such toys in days of old—  
A shred of golden hair lay curl'd;  
Worth all the gold of all the world,  
Perchance, to him who shrin'd it so:

Ah, 'twas a hundred years ago!  
But, dearest, if he loved as I,  
He loves unto eternity.

## MOONRISE IN THE ELSTER TANNEN-WALD

Darker than midnight, to the midnight sky  
Rises the valley-ridge with all its pines.  
Above that gloom a growing radiance shines,  
Where the full moon floats up invisibly.  
Now, half-revealed, she lifts her disk on high,  
When on it, lo! in black and spectral lines  
One blasted tree so wild a form designs,  
That fear and wonder hold the watcher's eye.

The minutes pass—and nothing looks the same,  
But tangled in a web of silver light  
Lies the great forest, dreaming and at rest.  
Yet deep in memory's core abides that sight  
One moment outlined on the mountain crest—  
A Shape that writhed upon a pool of flame.

## AFTER ALL—

When the time comes for me to die  
To-morrow or some other day,  
If God should bid me make reply,  
'What wilt thou?' I shall say:

O God, Thy world was great and fair,  
Yet give me to forget it clean;  
Vex me no more with things that were,  
And things that might have been.

I loved, I toiled—throve ill and well,  
Lived certain years, and murmur'd not.  
Now grant me in that land to dwell  
Where all things are forgot.

For others, Lord, Thy purging fires,  
The loves reknit, the crown, the palm.  
For me, the death of all desires  
In deep, eternal calm.

## EVENSONG

heart of a German forest I followed the winding ways  
cushioned with moss, and barr'd with the sunset's slanting rays,

out of the distance dim, where no end to the path was seen,  
the breath of the Springtime clung like a motionless mist of green,

like a sound of singing, unearthly-sad and clear,  
from the forest deeps and float on the evening air.

thought of the spirits told of in dark old forest lore  
as the greenwood singing for ever and evermore;

stopped and wondered and waited, as nearer the music grew,  
and still more loud—till at last came into view

of Saxon maidens, tanned with the rain and sun,  
laden of billeted wood on the shoulders of every one!

long steps never falter'd, the chanting passed away  
from the fragrant depths of the woodland, and died with the dying day.

Spirits in truth! yet it seem'd, as awhile in dreams I stood,  
that music more than earthly had passed through the dark'ning wood.

It seemed that the Day to the Morrow bequeathed in that solemn strain  
the whole world's hope and labour, its love, and its ancient pain.

## IN MEMORIAM: J. T. C. H.

In hours of respite from the strife  
That kills the careless joy of life,  
How often, friend, have you and I  
Lived o'er those golden days gone by,  
When eager hand and eager eye  
Against the humming salt sea-breeze  
Drove our light craft through breaking seas;  
Or when beneath enchanted woods  
We floated, where the shadow broods  
On still black waters, and delayed  
A little in the chequer'd shade  
To watch, far down the shining stream,  
The golden summer sunlight gleam  
On the green banks of storied Boyne.

Ah, in those happy days how well  
Did wood and field and water join  
To weave the wild earth's mighty spell!  
Gone, gone! and you are also gone,  
On dark tides that you sailed alone;  
And scarcely more for you than me  
Those days are done! O, morning sea,  
Where all the morning in our blood  
Sang, as we faced the glittering flood!  
O, bays the wild sea-murmur fills,  
And hot gorse-perfume from the hills!  
O, lonely places, echoing  
With sound of waters, wave or stream,  
Haunted by timid foot and wing,

I see you now but in a dream—  
Old days, old friends, we part, we part;  
Yet still your memory in my heart  
Lives, till the heart be dust; and then  
Beyond this realm of Where and When,  
Something of you shall linger yet,  
And something in me not forget,  
When all the suns of earth have set.

## TRANSLATIONS

# THE BATTLE OF SALAMIS

*From “The Persians” of Aeschylus*

[Except for inscriptions, this contemporary narrative of the Battle of Salamis is the earliest piece of written Greek history extant. The splendour and force of the original make it one of the greatest pieces of battle-narrative in the world, and defy adequate rendering. But it is noticeable that not only is the description ablaze with the passion of war, but the plan and tactics of the fight, which was probably even a more decisive event in world-history than that of Marathon, are given with a map-like precision and clearness.

The narrative is placed in the mouth of a messenger sent by Xerxes to his mother, Atossa, to tell her of the catastrophe. I have followed the text of Paley.]

ATOSSA

And is Athena’s city yet unsacked?

MESSENGER

Men were her city-wall—unbroken yet.

ATOSSA

Then tell me of the fight at Salamis.  
Who first began the onslaught—was’t the Greeks?  
Or made his swollen fleet my son too bold?

MESSENGER

Began? Some Power malign began it all!  
Some God that hated Persia. First, there came  
A Greek deserter from the Athenian host.  
“Keep watch,” he said, “for at the dead of night  
Our benches shall be manned, our fleet dispersed;  
They will escape you in the narrow seas.”  
This Xerxes heard, O Queen, and never saw  
The Greek man’s guile, nor knew the Gods his foe.  
To all the captains of the fleet he sent  
This order: “When the sun his fiery beams  
Hath hidden from the earth, and night holds all  
The empire of the air, then set your ships,  
Some ranged in threefold line to guard the friths  
And close up all the roaring waterways,  
Some to patrol the Isle of Salamis.  
And mark ye, should the Greeks escape their doom  
By one unguarded outlet, ’tis decreed  
Your heads shall fall for it.” So spake the King,  
Haughty, infatuate, knowing not the end.  
And dutifully they obeyed his word.  
Supper was first prepared; each oarsman then  
Looked to his tholepin and bound fast the oar.  
Then, as the sunlight faded from the earth,  
And night came on, the rowers went on board,  
And with them every well-trained fighting man;  
And soon from squadron unto squadron rolled  
Down the vast lines the cheering of the fleet,  
As each one rowed to his appointed place.  
So all night long the captains made us cruise  
Hither and thither, every ship we had;  
And now the night was spent, yet never once  
The Greeks had tried our watch in secret flight.  
But when the white steeds of the God of Day  
Mounted the sky, and light possessed the land,  
Then from the Greeks a mighty chant was borne,  
Triumphant, to our ears, and every cliff  
Of sea-girt Salamis pealed back the strain.

And fear possessed us every one, O Queen,  
And staggering doubt; for not as if in flight  
Rose the great pæan then among the Greeks,  
But as when brave men cheer themselves for fight.  
Then the heart-kindling trumpet spake, and then  
We heard the thunder of a thousand oars  
That swung together at the steersman's cry,  
And all at once the sounding furrows smote.  
Then soon full clear their charging line we saw,  
The right wing leading, and the main array  
A little after; and ere long we heard  
Such cries as these: "On, children of the Greek!  
Now for your fatherland, for freedom now!  
For wife and child, and for your fathers' homes!  
Now for the temples of your fathers' Gods!  
To-day we fight for all!" So cried they still,  
Nor were we Persians dumb, but sent them back  
Shouting for shouting. Little time there was  
To range our lines, until the brazen beaks  
Crash'd in among us. First, a ship of Greece,  
Leading the onset, rent off all the prow  
From a Phœnician. Each then sought a foe;  
And first we stemm'd the torrent of their charge,  
But soon our multitudes in the narrow seas  
Were thronged and hampered, nor could any now  
Bear help to other—yea, and many a time  
Friend hurtled upon friend, or rent away  
With shearing prow her whole array of oars.  
Meanwhile the Greeks around us fiercely charged  
From every side at once; the lighter barques  
Were soon o'erset; the very seas were hid,  
So strewn with wreck and slaughter; every strand  
And jutting rock-ledge was with corpses piled.  
We pressed in ruinous disordered flight,  
All that was left of Persia's mighty fleet;  
While they, like fishers when the tunnies swarm  
Within some narrow inlet, slew amain

With aught that hand could seize—with shivered oars,  
Fragments of wreck, they stabb'd, they stunn'd, they clove;  
And out beyond the channel shrieks and wails  
And panic fear possessed the open sea.  
Gods! could I speak, nor cease for ten full days,  
I had not told how thick disasters came!  
Know this, that never since the world began  
Perished in one day such a host of men!

# THE DEAD AT CLONMACNOIS

*From the Irish of Angus O’Gillan*

In a quiet-water’d land, a land of roses,  
    Stands Saint Kieran’s city fair,  
And the warriors of Erin in their famous generations  
    Slumber there.

There beneath the dewy hillside sleep the noblest  
    Of the Clan of Conn,  
Each below his stone: his name in branching Ogham  
    And the sacred knot thereon.

There they laid to rest the Seven Kings of Tara,  
    There the sons of Cairbrè sleep—  
Battle-banners of the Gael, that in Kieran’s plain of crosses  
    Now their final hosting keep.

And in Clonmacnois they laid the men of Teffia,  
    And right many a lord of Breagh;  
Deep the sod above Clan Creidè and Clan Connall,  
    Kind in hall and fierce in fray.

Many and many a son of Conn the Hundred-Fighter  
    In the red earth lies at rest;  
Many a blue eye of Clan Colman the turf covers,  
    Many a swan-white breast.

## SONG OF FINN IN PRAISE OF MAY <sup>[5]</sup>

*From the Irish.*

May Day! delightful day!

Bright colours play the vales along.  
Now wakes at morning's slender ray,  
Wild and gay, the blackbird's song.

Now comes the bird of dusty hue,  
The loud cuckoo, the summer-lover;  
Branching trees are thick with leaves;  
The bitter, evil time is over.

Swift horses gather nigh  
Where half dry the river goes;  
Tufted heather crowns the height;  
Weak and white the bogdown blows.

Corncrake sings from eve till morn,  
Deep in corn, a strenuous bard!  
Sings the virgin waterfall,  
White and tall, her one sweet word.

Loaded bees of little power  
Goodly flower-harvest win;  
Cattle roam with muddy flanks;  
Busy ants go out and in.

Through the wild harp of the wood

Making music roars the gale—  
Now it slumbers without motion,  
On the ocean sleeps the sail.

Men grow mighty in the May,  
Proud and gay the maidens grow;  
Fair is every wooded height,  
Fair and bright the plain below.

A bright shaft has smit the streams,  
With gold gleams the water-flag;  
Leaps the fish, and on the hills  
Ardour thrills the flying stag;

And you long to reach the courses  
Where the slim swift horses race,  
And the crowd is ranked applauding  
Deep about the meeting-place.

Carols loud the lark on high,  
Small and shy, his tireless lay,  
Singing in wildest, merriest mood  
Of delicate-hued, delightful May.

[5] I am much indebted to the beautiful prose translation of this song by Dr. Kuno Meyer which appears in *Ériu* (the Journal of the School of Irish Learning), vol. i., Part ii. In my free poetic version an attempt has been made to render the rhyming and metrical effect of the original, which is believed to date from about the ninth century.

# WENN ICH AN DEINEM HAUSE

*From the German of Heinrich Heine*

I Pass beneath thy dwelling  
Each morning, and am fain,  
My child, to see thee watching  
Still at thy window-pane.

With black-brown eyes of wonder  
Thou dost my going scan:  
“Who art thou, and what ails thee,  
Thou sorrowful foreign man?”

I am a German poet,  
Among the Germans famed—  
There, when they count their greatest,  
My name is also named.

And, little one, what ails me  
Ails Germans not a few;  
Count they the sorest sorrows,  
They name my sorrows too.

# **EIN FICHTENBAUM STEHT EINSAM**

*From the German of Heinrich Heine*

There stands a lonely Pine-tree  
On a bare northern height.  
'Mid ice and snow he slumbers,  
Wrapped in his mantle white.

He dreams about a Palm-tree  
In far-off Eastern lands,  
That droops, alone and silent,  
Above her burning sands.

# ZWEI KAMMERN HAT DAS HERZ

*From the German of P. Neumann*

μάλα γέ τοι τὸ μεγάλας ὑγείας  
ἀκόρεστον τέρμα, νόσος γὰρ αἰ  
γείτων ὁμότοιχος ἐρείδει.

*ÆSCH., Ag.*

Two chambers hath the heart:  
    There dwelling  
Live Joy and Pain apart.

Is Joy in one awake?  
    Then only  
Doth Pain his slumber take.

Joy, in thine hour, refrain—  
    Speak softly,  
Lest thou awaken Pain.

## LADY ISLAND, ON THE CHIEMSEE, BAVARIA

*From the German of Victor Scheffel*

The placid lake at even glides our boat, alone and slow,  
Sunset stand empurpled domes of everlasting snow,  
On island in the twilight dimly rise a convent's walls:  
The chimes the chant of vespers from the grey old minster falls—  
*Perenni Fons amoris, Consolatrix tristium,  
 Mater Salvatoris, ave Virgo virginum!*  
Rising, falling, mingling, dying, comes the solemn song,  
In dreamy undulations air and lake the tones prolong.  
The oars, and still the heart in worship, as the sweet bells toll,  
Feel as though God's angels bore to heaven a blessed soul.

# THE THREE RINGS: A FABLE

*From Lessing's "Nathan der Weise"*[6](#)

[Since Plato, no writer has understood better than Lessing the dramatic conduct of a philosophic dialogue. The following colloquy is a beautiful example of his art and of his thought.

Nathan is a Jew, famed for his wealth and for his wisdom, living in Jerusalem at the time of the Third Crusade. In the following scene he has just been summoned to the presence of the Sultan Saladin. He supposes that a loan of money is the Sultan's object. Instead of this, he finds that it is his reputed wisdom which has gained him the interview. Nathan is a man who cannot have taken his beliefs in spiritual things without examination; here, then, says Saladin, are three faiths contending for mastery, the Jewish, the Christian, and the Mahommedan. Each claims to be the true and only true religion. The claim cannot be true of more than one of them. Which of them, in his inmost soul, does Nathan hold to be justified? That he may have time to collect his thoughts, Saladin leaves the Jew alone for a while before he answers. Nathan, who does not yet know Saladin, is at first very doubtful of the *bona fides* of the Musalman prince in making this inquiry of him.]

## ACT III, SCENE 6

NATHAN  
(*alone*)

H'm, h'm. A strange request. Where do I stand?  
What will the Sultan with me ... what? I come  
Prepared for money, and he asks for ... Truth!

And this he needs must have as bare and bright  
As if the truth were coin!... Aye, were it coin,  
Old, well-worn coin, that men tell out by weight,  
Such might I find him! But new-minted coin—  
The stamp's enough: you fling it on the board  
And there's an end—not thus can Truth be told!  
Doth he conceive that truth is to be poured  
From head to head like gold into a bag?  
Who's here the Jew, I or the Sultan?... Yet  
Suppose in very truth he asks for Truth?  
How then? And verily it were too little,  
Too paltry a suspicion, to believe  
He used the truth but as a snare.... Too little!  
Ah, what is then too little for the great?  
Why should he break into my house? A friend  
Would surely knock and listen at the door  
Before he entered. I must tread with care.  
But how? but how? To play the stolid Jew,  
That ne'er will pass ... still less, no Jew at all;  
For 'then' he'll say, 'why not a Musalman?'  
Let me think.... Ha! I have it now. That saves me!  
Not children only can one satisfy  
With fables.... He is coming. Let him come!

*Enter Saladin.*

SALADIN

I have not come too quickly? Thou hast brought  
Thy meditation to an end? Then speak!  
None hears but I.

NATHAN

Nay, all the world may hear  
For aught I care!

SALADIN

So clear and confident  
Is Nathan in his wisdom? Ha! this I deem  
To be a sage indeed! Nothing to hide,  
Never to palter—but to stake his life,  
His blood, his goods, and all, upon the truth!

NATHAN

Yea ... if need were ... and if the truth were served....

SALADIN

One of my titles, Betterer of the World  
And of the Law, I hope from this day forth  
To bear with right.

NATHAN

Truly, a noble title!  
Yet, Sultan, ere I trust myself with thee,  
Wholly and unreserved, I ask thee first  
To hear a fable from me.

SALADIN

Wherefore not?  
From childhood I have ever loved to hear  
Fables, well told.

NATHAN

Well told? ah, that indeed  
Is scarce a quality of mine!

SALADIN

Again  
So proudly modest? Well, speak on, speak on!

NATHAN

In the grey morn of Time, there lived i' the East  
A man, who owned a ring of priceless worth,  
Gift of a well-loved hand. For stone it bore  
An opal, where a hundred lovely tints  
Played, and where dwelt the magic power to make  
Well-pleasing in the sight of God and man  
Whoever wore it in this faith—What wonder  
It never left the owner's hand? what wonder  
He made provision to retain it ever  
In his own House, an heirloom for all time?  
Thus did he order it: He left the Ring  
First to his best-belovèd son, ordaining  
That he in turn should leave it to the son  
He dearest loved; and so to the dearest ever.  
And still the owner of the Ring, apart  
From precedence of birth, by that alone  
Should bear the sway.... Sultan, you follow me?

SALADIN

I follow thee. Proceed!

NATHAN

And so the Ring  
Descended, till at length it came to one  
Who had three sons, all dutiful alike,  
Whom therefore he, perforce, must love alike;  
Only, from time to time the first would seem  
Most worthy of the Ring, and then the next,  
And then again the third,—as each he found  
Alone with him, the other two not by  
To share his overflowing love. To each  
His heart's fond weakness made him pledge the Ring.  
Thus all went smoothly ... while it could. But now  
His time to die draws near, and, sore perplexed,

The good man rues that two of the three sons  
That trusted in his word, must soon be left  
Deceived, affronted.... Mark, now, his device!  
All secretly he summons to his aid  
A cunning craftsman, and commands him fashion  
After the pattern of his Ring, two others;  
No cost, no labour to be spared, to make them  
Like to the first, in every point alike.  
And so 'tis done; and when the craftsman brings  
The finished work, not even the father's eye  
Can tell his own ring from the copies. Now  
Joyfully doth he summon to his side  
His three sons, one by one, and, one by one,  
Gives each his blessing—and a ring—and dies.  
Sultan, thou hearest me?

SALADIN

Yes, yes, I hear!  
Come, will thy fable soon be told?

NATHAN

'Tis told  
Already, for the rest is evident.  
Scarce is the father dead when comes each son  
Bearing his ring, and claims to be the lord  
And ruler of the house! What follows then?  
Examinations, quarrellings, complaints—  
In vain! Among the rings, the one true Ring  
Remains for all eyes indistinguishable.—

*[After a pause in which he waits for  
the Sultan's reply.]*

Well-nigh as indistinguishable, Sultan,  
As here, for us, to-day, the one true Faith.

SALADIN

How? This shall be thine answer to my question?

NATHAN

Nay, this shall but excuse me, if I trust not  
My judgment to decide among the rings,  
Made by the Father to the very intent  
That they should never be distinguished.

SALADIN

Yea,

The rings!... Thou playest with me! I had deemed  
The three religions, whereof question is,  
Were easily distinguished, even to points  
Of food, and drink, and clothing!

NATHAN

Only not

In this one thing—their proofs. All rest alike  
On history, or written or handed down.  
And history we take—is it not so?—  
On faith and trust alone. Whose faith, whose truth,  
Shall we confide in most? Surely in those  
Of our own folk, whose blood we are, whose proofs  
Of love were given us from our childhood up,  
Who ne'er deceived us, saving when, perchance,  
'Twere better for our weal. If this be so,  
How can I less in my forefathers trust  
Than thou in thine? Or take the other side:  
Can I demand from thee that thou shouldst charge  
Thine ancestors with lying, but for this,  
That mine be justified? Again, the Christian  
To both of us may plead the like defence.  
Art thou not answered?

SALADIN  
(*aside*)

By the living God  
The man is right! I must be dumb.

NATHAN

Now turn we  
Back to our rings again.—I said, the sons  
Made their complaints: each one before the Judge  
Made oath that from his father's very hand  
He had the Ring—and so in truth he had—  
After his father's promise, long before,  
That one day he should own the Ring and all  
Its rights—and this no less was true. The father,  
Each one averr'd, could ne'er have played him false.  
Rather than credit this—rather than nurse  
Against so loved a father, such a thought,  
How fain soever he had been to think  
Nothing but good of them, he must believe  
His brothers guilty of foul treachery.  
But surely one day he would find a way  
To unmask the villains—he would be avenged!

SALADIN

And now, the Judge? I am intent to hear  
What thou wilt put into his mouth. Speak on!

NATHAN

On this wise spake the Judge: "Either ye bring  
Right soon your father here before me, else  
I spurn you from my seat. What! think ye I  
Am here to answer riddles? Or do ye wait  
Until the true Ring find a tongue and speak?  
Yet stay! 'Tis said that in the true Ring lives

A magic gift, to make the owner loved—  
Well-pleasing before God and man. So good,  
This shall decide the cause; for never, surely,  
In this the false can emulate the true.  
Which of the three of ye is best beloved  
By the other twain? Marry, speak out! Ye are dumb!  
Mysterious power, that only backward works,  
Not outward from within! Lo, each of you  
Loves best of all—himself! So are ye all  
Deceived, and all deceivers. All your rings  
Are manifestly false. Belike the true  
Was irrecoverably lost; and so  
Your father, to conceal the loss, made three  
In place of one.”

SALADIN

Excellent, excellent!

NATHAN

“And so,” the Judge continued, “if ye now  
Are bent on Law, on that alone, and counsel  
Such as I can, will none—I bid you hence.  
But, if I counselled you, my rede were this:  
Take ye the matter simply as it lies.  
Each from your father had his ring—let each  
Be well persuaded that the ring he holds  
Is the true Ring. It may be that your father  
Was minded to maintain the tyranny  
Of the one Ring no longer. And ’tis certain  
He loved you all, and loved you each alike.  
Would not have one exalted, one oppressed.  
Mark that! and be it yours to emulate  
His great impartial love. Strive, each of you,  
To show the Ring’s benignant might his own;  
Yea, help the mystic power to do its kind,  
With gentleness, with loving courtesy,

Beneficence to man, and unto God  
The deep devotion of the inmost soul.  
And when, full many a generation hence,  
Within your children's children's hearts  
The mystery of the Ring is manifest,  
Lo! in a thousand thousand years, again  
Before this judgment-seat I summon you,  
Where one more wise than I shall sit and speak.  
Now go your ways." So spake the modest Judge.

SALADIN

God! God!

NATHAN

And now, O Saladin, if thou  
Art confident that thou indeed art he,  
The wise, the promised Judge....

SALADIN

I? dust! I? nothing!

O God!

NATHAN

What moves the Sultan?

SALADIN

Nathan, Nathan,  
The thousand thousand years are not yet done!  
Not mine that judgment-seat! Enough—farewell!  
But henceforth be my friend.

[6] The concluding twenty lines of this translation have appeared in the writer's "Life of Lessing" (Walter Scott).

FINIS.

\*\*\* END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK SEA SPRAY:  
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